

“My Name Is Jahan”: Queer Time, Anti-Futurity, and the Refusal of Reproductive Temporality in Saad T. Farooqi’s *White World*

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Abstract

This article examines the construction of queer temporality and anti-futurity in Saad T. Farooqi’s dystopian novel, *White World* (2024) through the theoretical lenses of Lee Edelman’s reproductive futurism and Jack Halberstam’s queer time. Set in a 2083 Pakistan where a nuclear catastrophe has “burned the sky away,” the novel depicts a state organized around the fantasy of “New Pakistan”; a walled city for “true Muslims” from which queer, trans, and apostate bodies are violently expelled to the Badlands. This article argues that *White World* represents the Pakistani state’s investment in heteronormative reproduction as a logic of exclusion that renders queer lives impossible. Against this, the novel constructs alternative temporalities through its queer and trans characters: Jahan, whose transition reclaims time from biological determinism; Kanz, whose gay identity is pathologized yet persists; and the children of the shelter, who survive the state’s violence and inherit the ruins to imagine a future outside reproductive logic. The article demonstrates how Farooqi reconfigures the figure of the child—moving from Edelman’s emblem of heteronormative futurity to a survivor who builds queer futures from waste. Ultimately, this reading positions *White World* as a crucial contribution to South Asian speculative fiction and queer postcolonial studies, offering a vision of futurity that is neither despair nor assimilation but a precarious, care-based survival.

Keywords: queer temporality, anti-futurity, reproductive futurism, dystopian fiction, transgender studies

Introduction

The relationship between nationalism, religion, and sexuality in Pakistan has long been characterized by a politics of exclusion that targets queer, transgender, and non-normative bodies. Since its inception in 1947, Pakistan has defined itself as a nation for Muslims. Yet, this identity has consistently demanded the expulsion of those who deviate from rigidly defined religious, sexual, and gendered norms. The Hudood Ordinances of 1979, Section 377 of the Pakistani Penal Code, and the ongoing violence against transgender communities (who were only legally recognized in 2018) attest to a state apparatus invested in what scholars have termed “reproductive futurism” (Edelman, 2004), a political logic that stakes the nation’s future on the reproduction of heteronormative, religiously pure subjects. In this context, queer and trans existence becomes not merely a personal identity but a political threat to the very idea of Pakistan’s future.

Saad T. Farooqi’s dystopian novel *White World* (2024) amplifies this historical reality into a speculative nightmare. Set in 2083 Pakistan, after a nuclear war has “burned the sky away” and a radioactive snowfall blankets the land, the novel depicts a society organized around the military state’s fantasy of “New Pakistan”: a walled city for “true Muslims” from which all others have been expelled. The novel’s world-building literalizes the historical logic of Pakistani nationalism: Sunnis in Sector 1, Shiites in Sector 2, Christians and Hindus in Sector 3, and “palets” (apostates, queer individuals, and other “untouchables”) in the Badlands. This spatial segregation makes visible what the Pakistani state has always attempted to render invisible: that the nation’s claim to purity depends on the violent expulsion of those who do not fit.

Despite a growing body of scholarship on queer temporalities in Anglophone and European literature, there remains a significant gap in the analysis of how South Asian speculative fiction—particularly Pakistani dystopian literature engages with questions of queer time, anti-futurity, and the critique of heteronormative nationalism. Existing studies of Pakistani literature in English have predominantly focused on partition narratives, diasporic identity, and postcolonial trauma (Shamsie, 2005; Aslam, 2008; Jalil, 2015). While these are important contributions, they have largely overlooked how contemporary Pakistani fiction, particularly in the speculative mode, is developing sophisticated critiques of the state’s biopolitical management of sexuality and reproduction. Farooqi’s *White World* offers a unique opportunity to address this gap, as it explicitly thematizes the relationship between queer identity, state violence, and the politics of futurity in a context where reproductive heteronormativity has been weaponized as a tool of exclusion.

This study is significant for several reasons. First, it contributes to the growing field of queer postcolonial studies by demonstrating how a Pakistani dystopian novel uses the speculative genre to critique the state’s investment in reproductive futurity. Second, it extends the work of queer temporal theorists, particularly Lee Edelman and Jack Halberstam, into a non-Western context, testing the applicability and limitations of their frameworks in a setting where the state’s heteronormativity is explicitly articulated through religious nationalism. Third, it offers a new reading of *White World* that centres its queer and trans characters; Jahan, Kanz, and the children of the Badlands, as central to the novel’s political vision, rather than as marginal figures. Finally, this study addresses a broader gap in literary criticism: the underrepresentation of Pakistani speculative fiction in conversations about queer temporality and anti-futurity.

This article pursues three objectives:

1. To analyze how *White World* represents the Pakistani state’s investment in “reproductive futurism” (Edelman, 2004) through the fantasy of “New Pakistan” and the spatial segregation of queer and non-normative bodies.

2. To examine how the novel constructs “queer time” (Halberstam, 2005) as an alternative temporality that refuses the logic of marriage, reproduction, and inheritance, particularly through the figures of Jahan, Kanz, and Avaan and Doua’s childless relationship.
3. To demonstrate how the novel reconfigures the relationship between children and futurity, moving from the child as a symbol of heteronormative continuity (Edelman’s critique) to the child as a survivor of the old order who inherits the responsibility to build something radically new.

The following research questions guide this study:

1. How does *White World* represent the Pakistani state’s deployment of religious nationalism to enforce reproductive heteronormativity, and what does this representation reveal about the relationship between biopolitics and futurity?
2. In what ways do the novel’s queer and trans characters, Kanz, Jahan, and the children of the Badlands, embody alternative temporalities that challenge the state’s investment in linear, reproductive time?
3. How does the novel’s conclusion, the destruction of New Pakistan and the survival of the Badlands children, reconfigure the relationship between queerness, futurity, and political hope?

Queer Temporality: Theoretical Origins and Debates

The concept of queer temporality emerged in the late 1990s and early 2000s as queer theorists began to question the implicit heteronormativity of conventional understandings of time. Elizabeth Freeman (2010) argues that “chrononormativity”, the organization of time according to reproductive, capitalist, and familial rhythms, structures social life in ways that render queer existence unintelligible. Dinshaw et al. (2007) similarly propose the concept of “queer temporalities” as a way of understanding how queer lives are lived “out of sync” with normative life stages.

The foundational texts in this field are Lee Edelman’s *No Future: Queer Theory and the Death Drive* (2004) and Jack Halberstam’s, *In a Queer Time and Place: Transgender Bodies, Subcultural Lives* (2005). Edelman’s polemical argument is that the logic of “reproductive futurism”, the political investment in the Child as the emblem of social hope, structures all political discourse in ways that necessarily exclude queerness. For Edelman, queerness represents the “death drive” that reproductive futurism must expel, and the only genuinely queer political stance is a radical refusal of futurity itself: “Fuck the social order and the Child in whose name we’re perversely taught to shake the dust from our feet” (Edelman, 2004, p. 29).

Halberstam offers a different, more optimistic account of queer temporality. Drawing on the lives of queer and trans people, particularly within subcultures, Halberstam (2005) argues that queer lives are characterized by “alternative temporalities” that refuse the logic of “reproductive time” (marked by marriage, child-rearing, and inheritance). For Halberstam, queer time is not merely a refusal but a creative practice: “Queer time... emerges most spectacularly at the end of the twentieth century, in the context of the AIDS epidemic, where the premature death of many young gay men made evident the limits of reproductive time and of the life cycle” (p. 2). Halberstam’s framework allows for the possibility of queer futures, even if they are not organized around the child.

Queer Temporality in Postcolonial and South Asian Contexts

Scholars have increasingly applied queer temporal frameworks to postcolonial and South Asian contexts, often critiquing the implicit Eurocentrism of early queer theory. Gopinath (2005) argues that queer diaspora studies must attend to the “alternative temporalities” of postcolonial migration, where the past is not simply left behind but carried forward in ways that disrupt linear narratives of assimilation. In *Unruly Visions*, Gopinath (2018) extends this analysis to contemporary queer art and activism, showing how queer South Asian artists use archival practices to create “queer diasporic time” that refuses the logic of national belonging.

Within Pakistani literary studies, scholars have begun to examine representations of queerness and trans identity. Khan (2020) analyzes the representation of transgender characters in Urdu fiction, arguing that these texts often position trans identity within a framework of Sufi mysticism that offers alternatives to heteronormative Islam. Abbas (2021) examines contemporary Pakistani English fiction, noting that queer characters often function as figures of critique against the state’s religious nationalism. However, both Khan and Abbas note that these representations often remain within a tragic framework, where queer lives end in death or exile.

Dinshaw (2012) offers a related concept, “touching the past”, that illuminates how queer subjects might relate to history differently. Drawing on medieval literature and contemporary queer art, Dinshaw argues that queer temporality is characterized by a “desire for a history that is not straight” (p. 24), a desire that manifests in practices of anachronism, archiving, and alternative genealogies. This framework is particularly relevant to *White World*, where the past (the shelter, the lost children, the burned sky) is constantly “touched” in ways that disrupt the state’s attempt to foreclose it.

Dystopian Fiction and the Critique of Reproductive Futurity

Dystopian fiction has long been concerned with questions of reproduction and futurity. Atwood’s *The Handmaid’s Tale* (1985) presents a society organized entirely around the state’s control of female reproduction, while McCarthy’s *The Road* (2006) imagines a future where the child is the last remaining symbol of hope in a ruined world. More recently, scholars have examined how contemporary dystopian fiction critiques the politics of reproduction. Bouson (2010) argues that feminist dystopias expose the ways that reproductive futurity has been used to control women’s bodies. Johns-Putra (2016) examines how climate fiction represents the child as a figure of both hope and anxiety in the Anthropocene.

However, there has been less attention to how South Asian dystopian fiction engages with these questions. Farooqi’s *White World* joins a growing body of South Asian speculative fiction, including works by Samit Basu, Vandana Singh, and Manjula Padmanabhan, that uses the dystopian mode to critique religious nationalism and the state’s management of sexuality. Yet within this body, *White World* is distinctive for its explicit engagement with queer temporal theory, its representation of trans identity, and its refusal to resolve its critique into either despair or easy optimism.

The literature review reveals a significant gap: while queer temporal theory has been extensively applied to Western and European literatures, and while South Asian speculative fiction is gaining

scholarly attention, there has been no sustained analysis of how a Pakistani dystopian novel uses queer temporalities to critique the state's reproductive heteronormativity. Furthermore, existing studies of *White World* have focused primarily on its representation of religious violence, climate catastrophe, and the figure of the apostate (Bandukwala, 2024; Hardcastle, 2024; Jamal, 2024), with little attention to its queer and trans characters. This study addresses this gap by offering a queer temporal reading of *White World* that centres Jahan, Kanz, and the children of the Badlands as figures of alternative futurity.

Reproductive Futurism

Lee Edelman's concept of "reproductive futurism" provides the first pillar of this study's theoretical framework. In *No Future* (2004), Edelman argues that political discourse in modernity is organized around the figure of the Child, an emblem of social hope and futurity that demands sacrifice in the present. This logic, Edelman contends, is inherently heteronormative: "The Child... represents the telos of the social order and comes to be seen as the one for whom that order is held in perpetual trust" (p. 11). For Edelman, queerness represents the "death drive" that reproductive futurism must expel, a figure of negativity, non-reproduction, and the refusal of social meaning. Edelman's radical conclusion is that queerness should embrace this position, refusing the demand to participate in a social order that can only include queerness by making it "productive" for the future.

Edelman's framework has been extensively critiqued for its pessimism and its implicit privileging of gay male experience (Halberstam, 2005; Muñoz, 2009). However, it remains valuable for analyzing how states and societies deploy the figure of the child to justify violence against queer and non-reproductive bodies. In *White World*, the state's fantasy of "New Pakistan" is explicitly organized around a logic of reproductive futurity: the "true Muslims" who will inherit the future must be protected from contamination by queer, apostate, and other "wasted" lives.

Queer Time

Jack Halberstam's concept of "queer time" offers a complementary framework that attends to the alternative temporalities of queer and trans lives. In *In a Queer Time and Place* (2005), Halberstam argues that queer lives are lived outside the normative life cycle of "reproductive time" (birth, marriage, child-rearing, inheritance). Instead, queer time is characterized by "the potential to live outside of chrononormativity, to live in ways that challenge the organization of time according to the dictates of capital, family, and nation" (p. 10). Halberstam's framework is more optimistic than Edelman's, attending to the creative practices of queer subcultures, the formation of alternative kinship networks, and the possibility of queer futures.

Halberstam (2005) also emphasizes the importance of "transgender time", the ways that trans people experience time differently in relation to the body, transition, and the life course. For trans individuals, "the body can be the site of a radical reconfiguration of time" (p. 15), as medical transition, social recognition, and the reclamation of a gendered past create alternative temporalities that disrupt the linear, biological time of heteronormativity.

This study synthesizes Edelman's critique of reproductive futurity with Halberstam's affirmative account of queer time to analyze *White World*. The novel represents the Pakistani state's violence as organized around a fantasy of religiously pure reproductive futurity: "New Pakistan" is a space for the reproduction of "true Muslims," from which all non-reproductive, non-normative bodies have been expelled. At the same time, the novel's queer and trans characters, Kanz, Jahan, and the

children of the Badlands, embody alternative temporalities that refuse this logic. Jahan's transition, Kanz's gay identity, and the children's survival all represent ways of living outside reproductive time. Crucially, the novel's conclusion, the destruction of New Pakistan and the survival of the Badlands children, suggests a queer future that is neither Edelman's radical refusal nor a simple assimilation into reproductive futurity, but something else: a future built from ruins, by those who were meant to have no future at all.

The State's Reproductive Futurism: "New Pakistan" and the Expulsion of Queer Bodies

White World represents the Pakistani state's fantasy of "New Pakistan" as organized explicitly around a logic of reproductive futurity. The walled city, with its promise of "more food and water than a person could consume in a lifetime, electricity with no load-shedding, safety and protection, zero crimes, clean air. No snow" (Farooqi, 2024, p. 32), is reserved for those who fit the state's vision of the "true Muslim." This vision is not merely about religious identity but about the reproduction of a particular kind of subject, one who will reproduce the nation's purity into the future. The novel makes this clear through its system of color-coded clothing: blue for Shiites, red for Christians, orange for Hindus, and black for the "palets", apostates, queer individuals, and others deemed "untouchable." This system ensures that the future is visually organized around exclusion.

The novel's representation of Kanz exemplifies how the state's reproductive futurism pathologizes queer existence. Kanz, a gay man and former assassin, struggles with the religious teachings that tell him his identity is a sin. In a conversation with Avaan, Kanz articulates the logic of religious heteronormativity: "If I don't act on my impure desires, imam-sahib said I'm not sinning. Islam isn't unfair." (Farooqi, 2024, p. 36)

This formulation, that queer desire is acceptable only as long as it remains unrealized, reveals the logic of reproductive futurity: queerness can be tolerated only if it does not produce anything, does not create kinship networks, does not form families, does not reproduce. Kanz's internalization of this logic is devastating. When Avaan asks whether Kanz's brothers would have accepted his sexuality, Kanz deflects: "If I don't act on my impure desires... Islam isn't unfair" (p. 36). The novel shows how this logic destroys Kanz from within, leaving him an alcoholic who can only express his love for Jahangir through violence and longing.

The novel's representation of the state's violence against queer bodies is not limited to psychological internalization. The physical expulsion of queer and trans people to the Badlands makes visible the logic of reproductive futurity: these are bodies that cannot be allowed to reproduce the nation, so they are relegated to a space of death. Avaan reflects on the violence of this system: "It's a hell Pakistani Muslims made for me... We get pushed to the edge of society. We're threatened, violated..." (Farooqi, 2024, p. 170)

This hell is not merely metaphorical. The Badlands are a "death-world" (Mbembe, 2003) where those expelled from the state's reproductive future are left to die. Yet the novel also shows how this space of exclusion becomes a site of alternative kinship and queer community, a point to which we will return.

Queer Time and Alternative Temporalities: Jahan, Kanz, and the Refusal of Reproductive Logic

Against the state's reproductive futurity, *White World* constructs what Halberstam (2005) calls "queer time", alternative temporalities lived outside the normative life cycle. The most explicit representation of queer time in the novel is Jahan, a trans woman whose narrative arc traces a reclamation of temporality on her own terms.

Jahan's story begins with her childhood sense of being trapped in the wrong body. She describes her pre-transition self as existing in an "inch-wide sphere":

I existed in this inch-wide sphere, this dot. I breathed in this dot. I dreamed in this dot. No matter how many dreams I had, no matter how much I fantasized about being larger than this dot, about being the rest of myself, I was nothing outside this dot. (Farooqi, 2024, p. 105)

This experience of being "nothing outside this dot" is an experience of time as well as space. Jahan's pre-transition life is characterized by a temporality that is not her own; a body and life that move forward in time without her consent. Her transition, particularly the Nirvan surgery, represents a reclaiming of time:

It was a second. A second that was burning and sharp. I cried. Not in agony... As the blood flowed out of the fresh wound, the wound that used to be a knot that suffocated me, I felt my horizon widen. I felt larger than a dot. I watched the red pool grow wide between my legs. The burning, stinging pain grew hotter and hotter as the world throbbed in different shades of black. I cried with relief. I cried with some kind of joy. (Farooqi, 2024, p. 157)

This moment of transition is a queer temporal event, a rupture in normative time that allows Jahan to reorient her relationship to her past and future. Halberstam (2005) writes that for trans people, "the body can be the site of a radical reconfiguration of time" (p. 15). Jahan's Nirvan is precisely such a reconfiguration: the "second" that is "burning and sharp" is a moment when the linear, biological time of heteronormativity is shattered, and a new temporality, one in which Jahan can inhabit her own body and her own time, begins.

Jahan's relationship with Kanz further exemplifies queer time. Their five-year relationship is lived outside the logic of marriage, reproduction, and inheritance. When Kanz begins working for Humayun and earning money through assassination, the relationship falls apart, not because of the violence of the work per se, but because Kanz's labor becomes organized around the logic of accumulation that underlies heteronormative futurity. Jahan reflects on this collapse: "I was happy there. I could still be happy there... I would've been happy anywhere. As long as there's us." (Farooqi, 2024, p. 176)

Kanz's insistence on "giving us a life" through criminal accumulation, on building a future in the terms of heteronormativity, cannot accommodate the queer temporality that Jahan desires: a life lived in the present, as long as there is "us."

Avaan and Doua's relationship also exemplifies queer time. Their love produces no children, no inheritance, no lineage. Instead, it produces a shelter, a space of care for children who are not biologically theirs, who are the "waste" of the state's reproductive logic. Doua's reflection on the shelter reveals its queer temporality:

The library-shelter was my monument to motherhood. Not because I knew anything about being a mother or looking after children, but because in that cosy two-storey building, I did the opposite of everything Mama had done to me... Children painted there. They laughed and played. Children read whatever books I could find for them. They cried and fought there, but by the end of the day, nothing bad lasted. (Farooqi, 2024, p. 134)

This is a queer form of kinship; one based not on biological reproduction but on care, chosen family, and the creation of alternative futures. The shelter's children are not symbols of the future in Edelman's sense; they are not "the Child" for whom the social order is held in trust. They are survivors, gathered from the waste of the state's reproductive project, and they inherit not the promise of a better future but the responsibility to build something new from the ruins.

The Child as Survivor: Reconfiguring Futurity

Edelman's (2004) critique of reproductive futurism argues that the Child functions as a figure of political hope that always demands sacrifice in the present. For Edelman, the only genuinely queer political stance is a refusal of futurity itself, an embrace of the death drive that queerness represents. *White World* offers a different account. The novel's children, particularly Asha (Ash) and the other children of the shelter, are not the Child of reproductive futurism but survivors who must imagine a future radically different from the past.

The novel's treatment of Asha/Eksha, the twin sisters who are central to the trauma of the shelter, exemplifies this reconfiguration. Eksha is murdered, her body found in a garbage ditch, her organs removed. Avaan's memory of finding Eksha's mutilated sister, the one who survived, is devastating:

Through parted fingers, I watched a scrawny girl walk up to me, several blue, pink, and purple balloons in her right hand. But it was her left hand that I couldn't look away from. It was a ghastly fist... Like a prize, she brought it close to me, as she'd been taught... 'Asha?' I finally croaked... 'Eksha?' Her grey eyes glittered in a face that was scaled over with hunger and thirst. She bolted. I grabbed her arm... 'Who did this to you?'... She'd wanted to say bhaiyya. But she couldn't. They had cut out her tongue. (Farooqi, 2024, pp. 118-119)

This is the fate of the child in the state's reproductive futurism: to be mutilated, rendered speechless, made into a commodity. But Asha survives. When she reappears later as Ash, the leader of the resistance, she has transformed from victim to revolutionary. Her refusal to speak of her past, her insistence on being called Ash rather than Asha, represents a different relationship to time. Asha cannot return to the past; the shelter, her sister, her childhood are lost. But she can build something new.

The novel's conclusion, the destruction of New Pakistan and the survival of the Badlands children, offers a vision of futurity that is neither Edelman's refusal nor a simple return to heteronormativity. The children gather around Doua's funeral pyre, and Avaan and Jahan stand together, watching the old order burn. The final lines: "Behind us, Pakistan burns as it has for almost two days now. I grasp his hand tightly. 'Still here.'" (Farooqi, 2024, p. 293)

"Still here." This is not a triumphant declaration of a new beginning, but a quiet affirmation of survival. The future that the children will build is not promised; the logic of reproductive futurity does not guarantee it. It is something that must be built from ruins, by those who were meant to have no future at all. The novel refuses both Edelman's pessimism and the optimism of heteronormative futurity, offering instead a queer future that is contingent, precarious, and built on care.

Conclusion

This article has argued that Saad T. Farooqi's *White World* uses the speculative genre to critique the Pakistani state's investment in reproductive heteronormativity while simultaneously

constructing alternative queer temporalities that refuse this logic. Through the figure of “New Pakistan,” the novel represents the state’s fantasy of religiously pure reproductive futurity. This fantasy requires the expulsion of queer, trans, and non-reproductive bodies to the Badlands. Against this fantasy, the novel’s queer and trans characters embody what Jack Halberstam (2005) terms “queer time”: lives lived outside the normative life cycle of marriage, reproduction, and inheritance. Jahan’s transition, Kanz’s gay identity, and Avaan and Doua’s childless love all represent ways of living that refuse the state’s demand to reproduce the nation. Finally, the novel’s conclusion, the destruction of New Pakistan and the survival of the Badlands children, reconfigures the relationship between children and futurity, moving from the child as a symbol of heteronormative continuity (Edelman’s critique) to the child as a survivor who inherits the responsibility to build something new.

This reading of *White World* has implications beyond literary analysis. The novel’s critique of reproductive futurity speaks directly to contemporary Pakistan, where the state’s violence against queer and trans communities continues to be justified in the name of protecting the nation’s future. The 2018 Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, while a significant legal recognition, has been unevenly implemented, and violence against trans women remains endemic (Khan, 2020). The novel’s representation of the Badlands as a space of both abandonment and queer community offers a way of understanding the paradox of Pakistani queer existence: that the state’s attempts to expel queer lives create spaces where alternative forms of kinship and futurity become possible.

Future research might extend this analysis to other South Asian speculative fiction that engages with queer temporalities. Works like Manjula Padmanabhan’s *Escape* (2008), Vandana Singh’s *Ambiguity Machines* (2018), and Samit Basu’s *Turbulence* (2012) all represent futures in which gender, sexuality, and reproduction are reimaged. Comparative analysis across these texts would illuminate how South Asian speculative fiction is developing distinct queer temporalities that challenge both Western queer theory’s Eurocentrism and the heteronormativity of South Asian nationalism.

Ultimately, *White World* offers a vision of queer futurity that is neither despair nor easy optimism. The future that the Badlands children will build is not guaranteed; it is precarious, contingent, and built from ruins. But it is a future, a queer future, that is worth fighting for. As Jahan says at the novel’s end: “Still here.”

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